

My Personalized Summary: ARCSCU'25 Conference Keynotes

Keynote 1: Prof. Mahesha Kapurubandara

Topic: *Artificial Intelligence – Empowering Lives and Building a Better Future*

Prof. Kapurubandara explained AI in a relatable way—comparing its learning process to training a pet. She highlighted how AI is already part of everyday life through apps like Siri, Netflix, and online banking, where users benefit without needing technical skills.

She emphasized that **humans remain in control of AI**, as it lacks emotions, ethics, or creativity. It should support—not replace—us. For example, in agriculture, a student-led AI project predicted irrigation times using weather and soil data, saving water and increasing profits. In rural healthcare, AI tools now help connect patients to doctors remotely.

Prof. Kapurubandara encouraged students to use AI tools to manage time, reduce stress, and even support mental health. She noted AI's power in environmental protection, like satellite forest monitoring.

However, she also pointed out the risks—such as bias, energy consumption, and widening inequality. Her closing message was that the **future of AI depends on how we train and use it—AI reflects our input.**

Keynote 2: Mr. Kalana Muthumuni

Topic: *Capitalism and Sustainability – A Conscious Balance*

Mr. Muthumuni challenged the idea that profit alone drives innovation. He argued that while markets understand demand, sustainable growth needs more than just financial goals.

He shared examples like Venmo in the U.S. and Lanka Pay in Sri Lanka, showing how digital systems differ globally. He warned that unsustainable growth can be dangerous—like the downfall of Bee works due to poor financial planning.

He praised models that offer collateral-free loans to help small businesses grow. Mr. Muthumuni believes **“profit at any cost” doesn’t last.**

Today’s consumers, he said, prefer ethical and environmentally responsible brands. For instance, **Dilmah Tea donates 15% of profits to community projects**, showing how sustainability adds value. In fact, 10–20% of product pricing often reflects eco/social responsibility claims.

His takeaway: **Business should focus on long-term value, not just quick wins. Capitalism must align with sustainability to thrive.**

Keynote 3: Dr. Edward Braund

Topic: *Unconventional Computing – Exploring the Future with Biology*

Dr. Braund introduced **unconventional computing** as a fascinating field using biological, chemical, or physical systems for computation. Instead of traditional silicon chips, he discussed systems like:

- **Biological:** Slime mold (*Physarum polycephalum*) that can solve problems like mazes.
- **Chemical:** Systems like the Belousov-Zhabotinsky reaction.
- **Physical:** Devices like **memristors** that link charge and magnetic flow.

He explained how these new methods can be more energy-efficient and eco-friendly. For example, **Physarum-based experiments** used voltage changes to create music and perform logic operations. These systems can even combine multiple senses—like light, chemicals, and touch—for **multimodal sensing**.

Dr. Braund also talked about building special containers to house these systems and how biological computing might one day help in creating **self-repairing systems** or even **artificial skin** for robots.

Final Reflection:

These speeches inspired me to see how **technology, ethics, and sustainability can come together**. Whether it's AI supporting farmers, capitalism funding community growth, or slime molds powering futuristic computers, the future is in the hands of learners and innovators like us.

Keywords: AI, Sustainability, Unconventional Computing, Biological Systems, Social Impact, Ethical Innovation